Checkride day

Edition Oct 2026

Before you can test (61.39)

Knowledge test passed within the **24 calendar months** before the test month · age 18 and the experience · instructor endorsement: trained within the **2 calendar months** before the month of application, ready, and weak knowledge-test areas reviewed · signed application.

Bring (PTS checklist)

For the balloon: airworthiness and registration certificates · operating limitations · maintenance records showing inspections and AD compliance · balloon flight manual.
Equipment: the PTS, a current chart, computer and plotter, flight log, current AIM.

For you: photo and signature ID · pilot certificate · medical certificate or statement (the PTS lists it; 61.23(b)(10) needs none for a balloon checkride) · FAA Form 8710-1 with your instructor's signature · knowledge test report · logbook with endorsements · Form 8060-5 if retesting · approved school graduation certificate, if any · examiner's fee.

Areas of operation (FAA-S-8081-18A)

Area	What they ask
I Fundamentals of instructing	Learning and teaching; instructor responsibilities (always) plus at least one other task
II Technical subjects	Aeromedical factors, scanning, principles of flight and false lift, Parts 1, 61, 91 and 830, airspace, the logbook entries and endorsements you will give
III Preflight preparation	Certificates, medical and inspections; weather and go/no-go; a planned maximum-duration flight with real-time weather; performance; systems
IV Preflight lesson	Teach one maneuver from Areas VII–XI as you would to a learner
V Preflight procedures	Launch site, crew briefing, layout, inspection, inflation, basket management, pre-launch check
VI Airport operations	Frequencies, phraseology, ATC clearances
VII Launches and landings	Normal and over-obstacle launches; normal and steep approaches; normal and high-wind landings. Over-obstacle launch and high-wind landing go oral if conditions don't allow.
VIII Performance maneuvers	Ascents, level flight, descents, rapid ascent and descent, contour flying, obstacle avoidance, tethering, winter and mountain flying
IX Navigation	Airspace, landmarks against the chart, position, fuel, flight duration
X Emergency operations	Malfunctions, emergency and survival gear, water landing, thermals
XI Postflight	Recovery with the landowner, deflation and pack-up, refueling and propane

Sources: 14 CFR 61.39, 14 CFR 61.23(b)(10), FAA-S-8081-18A (Nov. 2023), Applicant's Practical Test Checklist (Balloon), FAA-S-8081-18A Section 1, Areas of Operation I–XI. Original card, not an FAA document. Study aid, not for navigation.